Lesson 37: Introducing and Explaining Evidence

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 4: Research and Evidence

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 4.7 Introducing and Explaining Evidence.

In this lesson

You learn to wrap every piece of evidence in context and explanation (the "sandwich"), to introduce a source with a credential and a reporting word, and to choose the reporting word that matches what the source did: argue, show, suggest, warn and many more. Then you write evidence sandwiches with your own research sources, as you will in every university paper.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Introduce a quotation or paraphrase with the source's name, credential and a reporting word.
- Choose reporting words that match the meaning and type of the evidence.
- Use the correct tense and grammar with reporting verbs, "tell" and "according to".
- Explain evidence after you present it, so that it supports your point.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
dropped quote (dumping a quote)	a quotation put into a paragraph with no introduction	a quotation followed only by (Abutalebi qtd. in Vince)
context	information before the evidence: who the source is and what kind of evidence it is	Cognitive neuropsychologist Jubin Abutalebi ... has found through brain scans that ...
cre·DEN·tial	information that shows why we should trust a source (job, field, institution)	of the University of San Raffaele in Milan, Italy
qtd. in	"quoted in": the person's words appear in another source	(Abutalebi qtd. in Vince)
reporting word	a word or phrase that tells who said what, and what kind of thing they said	says, argues, according to
explanation (analysis, significance)	sentences after the evidence: why it matters and how it connects to your point	In other words, ...

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
conclude / show	report a result based on research evidence	Bialystok concludes that being bilingual can delay the onset of dementia by about five years.
suggest	give evidence for an idea without being 100% definite	Bialystok suggests that dementia may be delayed ...
admit / acknowledge	report a concession or a different perspective	Vince acknowledges that many educators still discourage students from keeping their home language.
question	doubt or criticize (not "ask")	Bak questions the methods of the researchers ...

Rules and explanations

Context first: no dropped quotes

Your lesson material compares two uses of the same evidence:

- **Dropped quote:** the quotation stands alone, followed by (Abutalebi qtd. in Vince). This meets the minimum citation requirement, but readers wonder: Who is Abutalebi? Why is he here? How does he know this? Why should we believe it?
- **Introduced and explained:** "Cognitive neuropsychologist Jubin Abutalebi, of the University of San Raffaele in Milan, Italy, has found through brain scans that ..." The writer says who he is, gives his credentials, and names the type of evidence (a research finding) before the quotation. After it, the writer explains why the evidence is important.

After the first mention, the last name is enough (Abutalebi), because readers already know who he is.

The sandwich

Part	What it contains
top bread: context	source + credential (first mention) + reporting word
filling: evidence	the quotation or paraphrase, with its citation
bottom bread: explanation	why the evidence matters and how it supports your point

Text evidence does not usually go in the topic sentence or in the last sentence of a body paragraph.

Tense of reporting verbs

- Usually **simple present**: we write as if all the authors were in one room, each saying their idea, even if they wrote it years ago. Remember the -s for a singular person or organization: Smith argues ..., the Department of Agriculture reports ...
- For a **past event or action** (for example, research someone did), use the simple past or present perfect: Abutalebi **has found** through brain scans that ...

Grammar: say, state, tell, according to

"Say" can go in three places; the first is the most common in academic writing.

Position	Example
before the quote	Science editor Gaia Vince says, "Multilingualism has been shown to have many social, psychological and lifestyle advantages."
after the quote	"Multilingualism has been shown to have many social, psychological and lifestyle advantages," says science editor Gaia Vince.
inside the quote	"Multilingualism," says science editor Gaia Vince, "has been shown to have many social, psychological and lifestyle advantages."

(In the book, the second example is missing its closing quotation mark; it is correct here.)

- **state** follows the same patterns. **tell** needs an indirect object: Gaia Vince tells **us**, "..."
- **according to** is a prepositional phrase, not a verb. Pattern: According to (source), (complete sentence). Add a citation if the source has a page number or the author's name is not in the sentence. Two common mistakes: using "according to" together with a reporting verb (According to Abutalebi, he reports that ...), and not putting a complete sentence after it.

Reporting words with special meanings

What the source writer does	Reporting words
makes a generalization based on observations	observe
focuses the reader's attention on something	point out
says the same thing as another source you just referred to	agree, confirm
refers to another source	cite
gives careful reasons	explain
emphasizes something not everybody agrees about	maintain, insist, argue
makes a statement based on research evidence	conclude, show
says something in passing, not as a main point	mention
talks about future possibilities	predict, warn, hope
discusses an idea but is not 100% definite	suggest
does not believe something is true	deny, doubt, question
asks a question	ask, wonder
makes a concession or describes a different perspective	admit, acknowledge

In academic English, **question** means "doubt" or "criticize". To report a question, use **ask** or **wonder**.

Explaining evidence

Add at least a sentence or two after the evidence: why is it important, and how does it connect to your topic sentence and thesis?

- **You may write:** interpretation (the deeper meaning), emphasis or impact (why it matters), cause and effect, comparison, condition (if/unless ...), evaluation (why something is better or worse), personal connection (only if the assignment allows it).
- **Do not:** end the paragraph with the evidence; repeat the evidence or context; tell what happened next in a story or in reality; use personal experience if the assignment does not allow it.
- **Sentence starters:** In other words, his/her/their point is ... · As this quote/example shows, ... · Basically, X is saying Y. · [The author's] point is that Y. · The essence of [the author's] argument is that Y. · Given these findings, ... · Based on this surprising increase/decrease, ...

> **Psychology note:** In APA style (psychology), the year goes next to the author's name, and verbs that report published research are usually in the past tense or present perfect: Smith (2020) found that ...; researchers have shown that ...

Practice

Exercise 1. Choosing effective reporting words. These sentences are from "Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit" by Gaia Vince. The reporting word(s) have been replaced with X. Which word did she use? Think about what kind of idea the evidence is (a fact, an opinion, a conclusion?), and use the grammar pattern as a clue.

1. "If you look at modern hunter-gatherers, they are almost all multilingual," X Thomas Bak. [doubts / says / concludes]
2. "From this [study], Ervin-Tripp X that human thought takes place within language mindsets, and that bilinguals have different mindsets for each language..." [concludes / insists / warns]
3. "When I did the same test again after completing the . . . task, I was significantly better at it, just as Athanasopoulos has predicted. 'Learning the new language improved your performance the second time around,' he X." [denies / explains / argues]
4. "The result of my test in Athanasopoulos's lab X that just 45 minutes of trying to understand another language can improve cognitive function." [questions / maintains / suggests]
5. "Strowger X me that the program has had many benefits in addition to their grades, including improving students' engagement and enjoyment, increasing their awareness of other cultures so that they are equipped as global citizens, widening their horizons, and improving their job prospects." [tells / says / according to]

Exercise 2. Correct or incorrect? Correct the sentences that have a mistake.

1. According to Vince, she argues that European imperialism may have led to the false belief that encouraging bilingualism in children is harmful.
2. Science editor Gaia Vince tells, "Multilingualism has been shown to have many social, psychological and lifestyle advantages."
3. Vince wonders whether there are "really two separate minds in a bilingual brain."
4. Vince questions, "What will happen if the current rich diversity of languages disappears and most of us end up speaking only one?"

5. According to several recent studies, the greater empathy of bilinguals.
6. Language expert Alex Rawlings insist that it is actually easier to learn new languages as an adult than as a child.
7. Some policymakers doubt the benefits of bilingualism, despite the support of extensive research.
8. A study in 1962 by Peal and Lambert showed, "Bilingual children did better than monolinguals in both verbal and non-verbal intelligence tests."

Exercise 3. Analyze a sandwich. Read the second Abutalebi example in your lesson material (it begins "Cognitive neuropsychologist Jubin Abutalebi").

1. What is Abutalebi's credential?
2. Which words tell the reader what kind of evidence this is?
3. Why is the reporting verb "has found" and not "finds"?
4. Which sentences are the explanation, and which kinds of explanation do they use?

Exercise 4. Add the bottom bread. This evidence already has context: "From her research on aging bilinguals at York University, psycholinguist Ellen Bialystok concludes that being bilingual can delay the onset of dementia by about five years." Write one or two sentences of explanation. Use a sentence starter, and do not simply repeat the evidence.

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to Exercises 2 and 4."
- "Here is a paragraph from my draft: [paste]. Find any dropped quotes, and tell me whether each source has a credential the first time it appears."
- "Here is a quotation from one of my sources: [paste]. I will introduce it in three ways: with 'says', with 'according to', and with a verb that has a special meaning. Tell me which version is the most accurate and if the grammar is correct."
- "Read me five sentences from a psychology article with the reporting verbs removed. I will guess the verbs and explain my choices."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each | mark.

1. "Multilingualism," | says science editor Gaia Vince, | "has been shown to have many social, psychological and lifestyle advantages."
2. According to several recent studies, | bilinguals show more empathy | and can guess other people's feelings more accurately.
3. Bak maintains | that "the detractors have made errors in their experimental methods."
4. Bialystok suggests that dementia may be delayed | "because bilingualism rewires the brain and improves the executive system."
5. Vince ac·KNOWL·edg·es | that many educators still discourage students from keeping their home language.

Writing task

Your research project: two evidence sandwiches. Use the claim and evidence you chose in Lesson 36. Write one body paragraph of 180-250 words:

- a topic sentence with your claim (no evidence in it);
- two pieces of evidence from two different sources: one short quotation and one paraphrase;
- before each one: the source's name, a credential (the first time) and an accurate reporting word;
- after each one: one or two sentences of explanation;
- a last sentence in your own words that connects back to your claim.

Self-editing checklist:

- Each piece of evidence is introduced with a source and reporting words.
- The first time a source appears, I give a credential.
- My reporting words match the type of evidence (for example, "argues" for an opinion, not a fact).
- The grammar patterns are correct ("tells us"; "according to" + a complete sentence; never both "according to" and a reporting verb).
- I use the present tense for what authors say, the past or present perfect for research events, and the -s for singular subjects.
- I explain every piece of evidence, and my explanation connects it to my point instead of repeating it.
- There is no evidence in the topic sentence or the last sentence.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Gaia Vince, "Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit", the article used in this lesson (the book's Mosaic link is dead; this is the same article, republished in a slightly adapted version): https://www.positive.news/science/bilingual-helps-keep-brain-fit/

Answer key

Exercise 1 (book)

1. says
2. concludes
3. explains
4. suggests
5. tells

Exercise 2

1. Incorrect (a reporting verb together with "according to"): According to Vince, European imperialism may have led ... **or** Vince argues that European imperialism may have led ...
2. Incorrect ("tell" needs an indirect object): Science editor Gaia Vince tells us, "Multilingualism ..."
3. Correct.
4. Incorrect ("question" means doubt or criticize): Vince asks, "What will happen ...?"
5. Incorrect (no complete sentence after "according to"): According to several recent studies, bilinguals show more empathy and can guess other people's feelings more accurately.
6. Incorrect (singular subject): Language expert Alex Rawlings insists that ...
7. Correct.
8. Correct (the simple past reports a past event: a study done in 1962).

Exercise 3

1. He is a cognitive neuropsychologist at the University of San Raffaele in Milan, Italy.
2. "has found through brain scans": it is a research finding.
3. It reports a past action (research he did), so the present perfect is used, not the simple present.
4. The two sentences after the quotation: "It may sound surprising that knowing two languages can literally change the actual physical structure of our brains, but that is the key to the mental benefits of bilingualism beyond the languages themselves. This extra gray matter makes our brains more flexible and resilient, and helps us understand other people better." (example answer) They show emphasis/impact ("It may sound surprising ... that is the key ..."), interpretation (the deeper meaning: bilingualism changes the brain's structure) and cause and effect (extra gray matter makes the brain more flexible).

Exercise 4 (example answer) In other words, her point is that a second language does more than help people communicate: it may also protect the brain as it ages. Given these findings, keeping a home language may matter not only for children's education but also for their health much later in life.

My notes